atrocities and planned terrorist attacks. Populist conspiracy theories alleged that most Rohingya were not really part of the people of Myanmar, but recent immigrants from Bangladesh, flooding into the country to spearhead an anti-Buddhist jihad. Buddhists, who in reality constituted close to 90 per cent of the population, feared that they were about to be replaced or become a minority.[12] Without this propaganda, there was little reason why a limited number of attacks by the ragtag ARSA should be answered by an all-out drive against the entire Rohingya community. And Facebook algorithms played an important role in the propaganda campaign.

While the inflammatory anti-Rohingya messages were created by flesh-and-blood extremists like the Buddhist monk Wirathu,[13] it was Facebook's algorithms that decided which posts to promote. Amnesty International found that 'algorithms proactively amplified and promoted content on the Facebook platform which incited violence, hatred, and discrimination against the Rohingya'.[14] A UN fact-finding mission concluded in 2018 that by disseminating hate-filled content, Facebook had played a 'determining role' in the ethnic-cleansing campaign.[15]

Readers may wonder if it is justified to place so much blame on Facebook's algorithms, and more generally on the novel technology of social media. If Heinrich Kramer used printing presses to spread hate speech, that was not the fault of Gutenberg and the presses, right? If in 1994 Rwandan extremists used radio to call on people to massacre Tutsis, was it reasonable to blame the technology of radio? Similarly, if in 2016–17 Buddhist extremists chose to use their Facebook accounts to disseminate hate against the Rohingya, why should we fault the platform?

Facebook itself relied on this rationale to deflect criticism. It publicly acknowledged only that in 2016–17 'we weren't doing enough to help prevent our platform from being used to foment division and incite offline violence'.[16] While this statement may sound like an admission of guilt, in effect it shifts most of the responsibility for the spread of hate speech to the platform's users and implies that Facebook's sin was at most one of omission – failing to effectively moderate the content users produced. This, however, ignores the problematic acts committed by Facebook's own algorithms.

The crucial thing to grasp is that social media algorithms are fundamentally different from printing presses and radio sets. In 2016–17,